Eelam/ he said. A. Amirthalingam said that he had spoken to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran to ensure better protection for the Sri Lankan Tamil youths who had been arrested there recently and disclosed that the discussions had been successful. 'Tigers are in safe hands/ Amirthalingam told the Tamil population.

A TULF spokesperson said that the fragmentation of the Tamil community was sapping its strength and they were making attempts to tie up with Muslim organisations in the eastern province, comprising districts like Arnpara, Batticaloa and Trincomalee. On the question of whether the TULF should contest the election, there were differences of opinion. India's Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) note dated 12 November 1982 said:

The TULF has not come out particularly well from the Presidential elections with its call for boycott being ignored to a very great extent. If the hold of TULF, which is currently moderate in its leadership, slips then one cannot discount a further fillip to extra constitutional activities by the Jaffna Tamils.

Nevertheless, Sri Lanka went to the polls on 20 October to elect an executive president and Jay e war dene won an outright majority with 52.91 per cent of the votes cast. Indian analysts believed the Tamil factor was also responsible for Jayewardene's victory. Approximately two hundred and eighty thousand Tamils were registered as voters. The Ceylon Workers Congress, the largest organisation representing plantation labour, threw its weight behind Jayewardene. He also benefitted because TULF, which represented the Sri Lankan Tamils who constituted about eleven per cent of the population, had